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Bill Loudon
(Director, International
Business Institute at
Austin Community
College; online game
industry pioneer)

Bill Loudon on the Role of Online Services :::::

Bill Loudon is one of the early pioneers in the online, Internet, and computer massively multiplayer online game (MMOG) industries. He was a founding member of CompuServe and Founder and President of GENie at the General Electric Company from 1985-1991. Bill designed and developed *MegaWars*, the first commercial multiplayer game, in 1982 while at CompuServe.

MegaWars was a science fiction, space exploration game based on multiplayer teams. The game ran continuously for over 18 years until it was retired in 2000. Bill was also instrumental in the production, licensing, and publishing of over two dozen multiplayer games that helped to launch Mythic Entertainment, Kesmai, and Simutronics. Bill teaches game computer industry courses at Austin Community College, where he is department chair and professor in International Business. He also teaches graduate business

courses in digital media at St. Edward's University in Austin.

In 1982, when I was in charge of games at CompuServe, I bought a copy of *DECWAR* on tape for \$50 and soon discovered that it did not run as hoped. It also was laden with many Star Trek and other copyright violations and had to be extensively modified before it could ever become a commercial product. I took *DECWAR* and made some major changes designing the game for CompuServe's Fortran IV language. Working with the "Wizard of Dec-10," Russ Ranshaw, the *MegaWars* game was developed. I also had to remove *Star Trek* related copyright names (no more Romulans, etc.), and develop a new scenario/storyline to become the first commercial MMOG, *MegaWars*. It went up on CompuServe in late 1982 and ran continuously until 1998.

The biggest design changes included different ship classes and goals, offline strategy and world-building components, exploration strategy, planetary economics, live team combat, and extensive team collaboration. By the time that game launched in 1983, it was much more complex and a commercially stable product in comparison to *DECWARS*—very little like the original.

In 1985, I moved on from CompuServe and convinced GE's Information Services division to set up a public service similar to CompuServe—using the evening hours excess capacity on GEIS's mainframe computers. Named GENie by my wife for "GE Network for Information Exchange," it was priced at \$5 an hour for both 1200 and 300bps—making it half the price of CompuServe at 1200bps.

I also convinced GE that in order to make the service a success, GENie would need online games. So in 1986, I hired Kesmai to rewrite *MegaWars* I and re-launched it on GENie as *Stellar Warrior*. The game ran for years—dying only when GE threw in the towel and unplugged the entire GENie service a few years after I had left.